



FITNESSWISE

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Balancing act: The art of load management

The **transition** from receiving accolades to playing the blame game can be a wild journey in sports.

Following the recently concluded 2023 ICC World Cup and other global competitions, we've seen a range of opinions and discussions about our performance being conducted on various platforms, be it social media, live broadcasts or traditional media. But, instead of dwelling on the technical or tactical aspects of the game, let's focus on its physical aspect, particularly the buzzworthy and fashionable term — load management.

When an individual athlete or a team achieves competitive success, it is only natural for the coaching and support staff to celebrate it. After all, success is often built on hard work, perseverance, planning, discipline, and sacrifices — something which they have been witness to. We also know that injuries are an inherent part of sports, and athletes who manage to stay injury-free throughout the season have a better likelihood of success.

So, how much of the success, be it team or individual, can be attributed to the head coach, medical staff or strength & conditioning coaches? When a team succeeds, is it due to good coaching or skilled players? And when it underperforms, why is the blame often on 'inadequate fitness'?

Team dynamics

It is a common tendency to hold the performance and sports medicine teams responsible for injuries — either for making them train too hard or for not providing adequate rehabilitation. This is the reality of sports today.

With so many diverse opinions available on the benefits and drawbacks of high-training methods and protocols, it's no surprise that sport coaches, performance & medical staff, and even athletes themselves, debate over the optimal approach to developing robust performances. There is no universal mantra for success that can apply to all athletes.

All over the world, sports teams at various levels, including high school, college, and professional, are recognising the importance of 'load management'. But who is 'responsible' for it? Is it the coach, the performance staff, or the medical team?

We dissect each of their roles to find out the answer.

Performance and medical teams

If the goal of the programme is to develop the physical prowess required for competitive success, the strength and conditioning staff will monitor training and competition workload.

On the contrary, if the goal is to minimise workload-related injuries, the responsibility for collecting this data often falls on the physio and medical staff. However, these answers only partially explain who is responsible for load, performance, and injury management.

There's a famous phrase that has been in vogue for a long time in sports: 'Strength and conditioning staff break athletes, and the medical staff fix them'. It's understood that inappropriate strength and conditioning programmes can increase the risk of injury. Rapid increase in training loads can result in poor performance.

However, not all injuries occur due to rapid increase in load, so not all the blame need to be attributed to the strength and conditioning staff.

If the medical staff are too conservative with their loading and progression strategies, it can also result in injuries, repeated ones at that, and consequently, poor performances. Clearly, both performance and medical staff play key roles in keeping athletes injury-free.

Coaching staff

Many coaches often state — "My performance staff, medical team, and other support staff handle athlete workload and performance domains. I'm a coach — that's